The 6:15

WEDNESDAY · OCTOBER 28, 2026 NO. 32

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS

Wed 10/28 (today)	FOMC rate decision 2:00p ET, Chair Warsh press conf. 2:30p ET — no SEP/dot plot this meeting; see Lead for the chair/rate correction. MSFT, GOOGL report Q3 after close **(consensus not verified this run)**. World Series Gm. 5, Tampa Bay at Tropicana Field, 8p ET — MIL leads 3-1, TB faces elimination.
Thu 10/29	Q3 GDP advance est. & Sept. PCE price index (BEA), jobless claims — all 8:30a ET **(one calendar source shows PCE on 11/4 instead — not reconciled)**; AMZN reports after close.
Sat 11/1	OPEC+ meets; Nov. quotas already set, unchanged, per its Oct. 4 communique.
Tue 11/3	Midterm elections — House control favors Democrats across prediction markets (85–95%); Senate genuinely contested, sources disagree on which party leads.

No confirmed frontier AI release, major rocket launch, or >$500M VC round in the last 48–72h — omitted rather than padded.

METRICS · ~6:15A ET UNLESS NOTED

Brent / WTI	$114.58 (+0.61%) / $101.16 (+1.26%) — oilprice.com, ~11-min delay; both below yesterday's $116.00/$102.04. Spread ~$13.42.
2Y / 10Y / 30Y	4.70% / 4.99% / 5.30% — Treasury.gov, Tue. 10/27 official close.
DXY	102.40 (+0.08%) — Yahoo Finance, 6:08a ET.
S&P / Nasdaq-100 / Dow futures	7,763.75 (+0.07%) / 29,913 (+0.34%) / 52,443 (-0.26%) — premarket, ~6:09a ET **(source's own header/ticker figures showed minor mismatches)**.
VIX	17.50 (-0.11%), 6:05a ET — down from yesterday's 18.25.

Gold	$4,048.60 (-0.26%), 6:18a ET — back above $4,000, up from yesterday's same-time $3,995.10.
Fed funds target	3.75%–4.00% **(corrected — see Lead)**; cut odds ~1% (Manifold), hold ~95%/hike ~6% (Kalshi-linked market) **(CME FedWatch unreachable again)**.
Asia / Europe	Nikkei 63,954.19 (+1.08%, 3:45p JST); Hang Seng 23,094.83 (+0.23%). Europe still mid-session at press time — FTSE 10,651.02 (-0.33%) as of 10:04a GMT, not a close.
Retail gas (AAA natl. avg.)	$4.2471/gal (10/28), down from Tue.'s $4.2661 — second straight decline.

Gold's overnight gain and crude's overnight pullback both run counter to a "hawkish Hormuz" read into today's Fed decision — see Lead.

HORMUZ COUNTERS — STRAITS.LIVE, 28 OCT 10:17Z (6:17A ET; FEED FLAGGED "DEGRADED")

Transits	4 vessels/day (~5% of 85/day baseline) — Oct. 18 IMF PortWatch reading, now 10 days stale.
Dark tankers, 24h	153/239 screened (64.0%) vs. 7-day avg. 101.8 tankers **(baseline switched from a % to a raw count this cycle — not directly comparable to yesterday's 70.8%)**.
War-risk premium	~32.0x pre-crisis — Oct. 7 estimate, 21 days stale; background only.
Indices	Crisis Pressure 88±13 (Extreme, band widened again from ±12 Mon.); Escalation Forecast 61±11 (High, flat).
Closure status	Day 241 per straits.live's transit framing.
Strikes, 24h (claimed)	straits.live now frames Mon. 18:40–19:09Z's tanker fire as an alleged mine strike per Iran's army — same incident as yesterday's "disabled tanker" item, reframed, not a second event **[DEVELOPING]**. Sirik/missile-fire and "completely closed" claims remain uncorroborated.

straits.live's own feed is flagged degraded, its transit series stale 37 hours. IRGC/state-media claims, UKMTO, PortWatch and the dark-tanker screen measure different things over different windows — never averaged or differenced here.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Season over (eliminated Oct. 7); no reported moves.
Knicks	No reported trades or signings in the last 24 hours.
Northwestern	No reported moves; bye week.

LEAD

MARKETS / FED DAY — A CORRECTION

The Fed's chair is Kevin Warsh, not Powell, and the base case today is a hold at 3.75%–4.00% — a correction, landing on the day it matters most

Start with a correction. The Federal Reserve's chair is Kevin Warsh, not Jerome Powell — the Senate confirmed him 54-45 on May 13, 2026, and he took the gavel May 15; Powell remains a Fed governor, a term that runs to 2028, but hasn't chaired a meeting in over five months. [fact] The policy rate itself has moved too: the FOMC voted 12-0 on Sept. 16 to raise the target range a quarter point, to 3.75%–4.00% — the first hike since July 2023. [fact] Yesterday's issue of this brief (No. 31) referred to "Powell" and to a target "3.50–3.75%, unchanged since June 17" — both wrong, and both fixed as of this issue. This brief's own archive tracked the hike and the chair change correctly as recently as Sept. 24; the error crept back in once Fed coverage lapsed for a month between meetings. Nothing else in prior issues is affected. [fact, correction]

Today is Warsh's second rate decision since that hike — the FOMC's two-day meeting concludes with the decision at 2p ET, followed by his press conference at 2:30p; there's no Summary of Economic Projections at this meeting, so no fresh dot plot. [fact] A hold is priced as close to a lock: a Kalshi-linked prediction market shows roughly 95% odds of no change, 6% of a hike, 1% of a cut;

Manifold's independent market also shows cut odds at 1%. CME FedWatch, the standard reference, again returned a server error at press time, so this brief is using the same prediction-market proxies as yesterday. [fact/flag] The mechanism worth sitting with: September's hike wasn't a one-off the committee is eager to reverse. Minutes released Oct. 7 said "most participants" judged a further increase "would likely be appropriate by year-end" — a hold today is a pause inside an active hiking cycle, not a pivot toward easing. [fact/read] Watch whether Warsh's 2:30p remarks reinforce or soften that December signal.

Crude, meanwhile, eased rather than extended Monday's shrug at fresh Hormuz incident claims: Brent trades at $114.58 and WTI at $101.16 this morning, both below yesterday's already-soft readings, even as Iran's army reframed Monday's tanker-fire incident as an alleged mine strike and threatened the vessel's owner, Sinokor, with legal action. [fact, DEVELOPING] If a resurgent energy-driven inflation shock were building, it isn't showing up in the tape — one of the arguments for a hawkish surprise today looks weaker this morning than it did Monday. [read]

Into this lands the week's two biggest prints: Microsoft and Alphabet report after today's close, Amazon follows Thursday — both within about a day of the Fed decision, and a day ahead of Thursday's Q3 GDP advance estimate and September PCE print. [fact] Consensus figures for all three aren't cleanly sourced this run: trackers disagree widely enough — Microsoft's EPS estimate alone ranges roughly $4.71 to $4.82 depending on source — that this brief isn't printing a hard number for any of them. [flag] The second-order read: a Fed that holds without signaling an end to its hiking cycle, landing hours before two mega-cap prints the market is already pricing for

strength, leaves little room for either name to miss quietly. Watch: 2p ET for the decision, 2:30p for Warsh, and after-hours tonight and tomorrow for Microsoft, Alphabet and Amazon. [read]

POLITICS

Presidential approval hit a fresh low in the Reuters/Ipsos poll released Oct. 19 (4-day survey, n=1,679, ±2pp): 31%, the lowest either Reuters/Ipsos poll has recorded in either Trump term, a point below the prior low found two weeks earlier. [fact, DEVELOPING] Other trackers don't agree on the trend's slope: RealClearPolitics' average stood near 38.9% as of Oct. 19, while a separate aggregate snapshot three days later (Oct. 22) showed roughly 36% — both above the Reuters/Ipsos read, and not reconciled against each other this run. [fact, flag] Six days from the midterms, prediction markets are lopsided on House control (Democrats favored at 85–95% depending on venue) but genuinely split on the Senate: one Oct. 24 forecast gives Democrats 62.1% odds of a majority, while a separate market has Republicans trading in the mid-50s — a real disagreement this brief isn't resolving by picking one. [fact, flag]

ECONOMICS

Thursday brings two of the week's bigger data points at the same 8:30a ET slot: the Commerce Department's Q3 GDP advance estimate and the September PCE price index, the Fed's preferred inflation gauge — most calendar trackers converge on Oct. 29 for both, though one source still shows the PCE print dated Nov. 4, a discrepancy this brief couldn't reconcile this run. [fact, flag] No evidence surfaced of a funding lapse affecting this week's BLS/BEA/EIA release schedule, unlike the shutdown-driven delays that hit the

October 2025 and February 2026 jobs reports — absent other information, this week's prints are assumed to proceed on schedule. [fact] The Atlanta Fed's GDPNow nowcast, which opened near 5.0% for the quarter, has since run as high as 6.2% before easing to 5.9% — the exact dates of those revisions weren't confirmable this run, so treat the trend, not the precision, as the signal. [read, flag]

BUSINESS

Wednesday's earnings (MSFT, GOOGL) land hours after the Fed decision; Thursday's (AMZN) lands the same day as the GDP and PCE prints — mechanics covered in the Lead. Beyond that: consensus estimates for all three diverge enough across trackers that none is printed as a hard figure here. Microsoft's EPS estimate ranges roughly $4.71–$4.82 depending on source; Alphabet's GOOG/GOOGL split shows $2.94–$3.02; one Amazon tracker shows $1.96 EPS on roughly $202 billion in revenue, with the caveat that Amazon's reported results have recently diverged sharply from consensus because of mark-to-market swings tied to its Anthropic stake (a $1.82 estimate against a $5.75 actual last quarter) — making any pre-print consensus figure a weak guide this cycle. [flag] Separately, AAA's national retail gas average fell to $4.2471/gal Wednesday, its second straight daily decline, even as crude eased only modestly overnight — a gap that, unlike yesterday's one-day retreat, is starting to look like a genuine turn. [fact, DEVELOPING] No other overnight M&A or guidance news surfaced.

IRAN & HORMUZ

Beyond the mine-strike reframing covered in the Lead, the broader picture moved on one count and held on the rest. The dark-tanker screen, which had been climbing since Friday, pulled back to 64.0% of screened tankers running dark in the past 24 hours (153 of 239) from Tuesday's 70.8% — though straits.live switched its seven-day baseline from a percentage (96.0) to a raw count (101.8 tankers) this cycle, so the two readings aren't directly comparable and this brief isn't differencing them. [fact, DEVELOPING] IMF PortWatch's transit count is still stuck at 4 vessels/day against the 85/day baseline, a reading now 10 days stale; straits.live's own feed carries a "degraded" flag and says its transit series has gone unrefreshed for 37 hours — a reliability caveat worth carrying forward. [fact, flag] The Crisis Pressure index held at 88 (Extreme) but its uncertainty band widened again, to ±13 from Monday's ±12; the Escalation Forecast is flat at 61 (High). [fact, continuity]

Monday's Sirik explosion and missile-fire claim, and Tuesday's claim from Iran's armed forces chief that the strait is "completely closed," remain uncorroborated by UKMTO, CENTCOM, or any flag state or insurer as of this morning. [fact, continuity] Diplomatically, nothing has moved past Foreign Minister Araghchi's Oct. 18 restatement of the seven-point reopening plan — lifting the US naval blockade and sanctions on Iranian oil exports, ending hostilities on all regional fronts — still on the table and under review in Washington; President Trump's dismissal of the Oct. 23 seven-vessel claim as fabricated remains unanswered by either government. [fact, continuity] OPEC+ meets Saturday, Nov. 1, with November quotas

already set, unchanged, per its Oct. 4 communique; no delegate has commented publicly on this week's incident claims. [fact]

SPORTS

Yankees	Season over; eliminated Oct. 7, swept 3-0 by Tampa Bay in the ALDS.
Knicks	1-3; beat Detroit 111-97 Tue. at MSG (Towns 27pts/20reb, Brunson 23pts/7ast) — avoided an 0-4 start. Next: at Philadelphia, Fri. 10/30.
Northwestern	6-1 (3-1 Big Ten); bye week — next game Sat. 11/7 vs. Iowa at Ryan Field.
World Series	Rays 4, Brewers 3 (12 inn.) Tue. at Tropicana — Ben Williamson's walk-off single avoided the sweep; Brewers lead 3-1. Game 5 tonight, 8p ET, Tampa — Rays face elimination again; Gm. 6 Fri. 10/30 and Gm. 7 Sat. 10/31, if needed, both at Milwaukee.

Correction. Issue No. 31 (Oct. 27) referred to the Fed chair as "Powell" and to a federal funds target of "3.50–3.75%, unchanged since June 17." Both were wrong: Kevin Warsh has chaired the Fed since May 15, 2026, and the FOMC raised the target to 3.75%–4.00% on Sept. 16. See Lead.

Continuity. Technology and Geopolitics (Russia–Ukraine) are cut this issue — no net-new, verifiable movement found this run: no confirmed frontier AI release, major rocket launch, or >$500M VC round in the last 48–72h; no dated Ukraine development past the single-sourced Oct. 11 energy-truce claim already carried.

Unverified figures flagged this issue: CME FedWatch (unreachable again; Kalshi-linked and Manifold proxies used instead); Microsoft/Alphabet/Amazon Q3 consensus figures (conflicting trackers); the exact Sept. PCE release date (10/29 vs. a conflicting 11/4 read); Atlanta Fed GDPNow's exact revision dates; Europe's closing levels (still mid-session at press time); the Sirik/missile-fire claim, the "completely closed" claim, and the mine-strike framing of Monday's tanker fire (all single- or state-media-sourced, uncorroborated). Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.